

+1 VOICINGS

Once voice-leading is in your hands, add ONE tension to every chord. Four questions, then play.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS — ANSWER THEM IN ORDER

1

What LEFT HAND STRADDLE?

1 + 7

1 + 9

1 + 5 + 7

1 + 6

2

FULL 7th chord or GUIDE TONES?

Full — R · 3 · 5 · 7

Guide — R · 3 · 7

3

What POSITION based on the previous chord?

P1

P2

P3

Should become automatic with practice — follow the P3 → P2 → P1 cycle (see Sheet VC1)

4

What available TENSION on this chord?

9

11

#11

13

Reference Sheet VB2 for the available tension on each chord

FOUR EXAMPLE VOICINGS — C MAJOR

Root (LH) Chord Tones Tension

Cmaj9

P1 · Full 7th · 1+7 straddle · 9 tension

LH

9

3

5

7

LH: C+B | RH: E-G-B-D

Cmaj13

P2 · Full 7th · 1+9 straddle · 13 tension

LH

3

5

13

7

LH: C+D | RH: G-B-E-A

Dm9

Guide tones · 1+7 straddle · 9 tension

b7

LH

9

b3

LH: D+C | RH: F-C-E

Am11

Guide tones · 1+7 straddle · 11 tension

b3

11

5

b7

LH

LH: A+G | RH: C-G-B

THIS IS ONE EXERCISE

Every combination from these four questions produces a beautiful, professional voicing. The options feel loose by design — **gravitate toward what you like**. Your ear is the judge. Master this exercise and you will sound professional immediately. The tension adds the color; the position handles the voice leading; the straddle establishes the harmonic foundation. All three working together = a complete voicing.